Dirac's Dilemma of the Economy of Inheritance: Parental Care, Equality of Opportunity, and Managed Inequality

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In a brief reflection on the principles of human society, P. A. M. Dirac articulated a structural tension between two widely affirmed norms: that it is good and natural for parents to improve the prospects of their own children, and that justice requires that all children have equal opportunities in life. These principles, each compelling on its own, cannot be fully realized together. This paper reconstructs Dirac's dilemma, connects it to the dynamics of compounding advantage and inheritance, and situates it within the broader history of political philosophy, including the work of Rawls, Dworkin, Cohen, Brighouse and Swift, Nozick, Murphy and Nagel, and others. The paper argues that attempts to eliminate the resulting injustices entirely risk damaging the non–zerosum structures that generate general prosperity, and defends a position of "managed inequality": a robust social floor and real mobility, combined with limits on extreme dynastic accumulation and an explicit acceptance of some residual, but constrained, inherited advantage.

I. INTRODUCTION

In a short talk later published under the title "The Futility of War" [1], P. A. M. Dirac offers a strikingly simple statement of a deep social problem. He notes that modern human societies are guided by (at least) two fundamental principles: first, that it is good and natural for parents to care for and provide for their children, even at substantial personal cost; and second, that justice demands that all children be given an equal chance in life. Dirac observes that these two principles, each attractive on its own, stand in direct conflict once considered together.

In his own words (paraphrasing), if some parents manage to secure better conditions for their children by making sacrifices, the children of those parents will inevitably enjoy better opportunities than the children of parents who do not or cannot do the same. Conversely, if the state really ensured that all children had equal chances, then there would be no point in parents making such sacrifices, since their children's prospects would be no better than those of others. Dirac concludes that these two principles "tend to exclude each other", and that the conflict between them underlies familiar ideological divisions between what he calls right–wing and left–wing outlooks.

Dirac does not present this as a solved problem; rather, he notes that actual societies seek unstable compromises between these values, avoiding extremes. The aim of this paper is threefold. First, to reconstruct the structure of Dirac's dilemma. Second, to connect it with the dynamics of compounding advantage, both financial and non-financial. Third, and centrally, to show how Dirac's brief remark fits into—and is illuminated by—a much larger body of work in moral and political philosophy concerning equality of opportunity, the family, inheritance, and the tension between partiality and impartial justice.

The conflict that Dirac identifies is not unique to physics-minded reflection. It lies close to the surface of liberal egalitarian theory (Rawls, Dworkin), of debates over "luck egalitarianism" and its critics, of recent work on the ethics of the family (Brighouse & Swift; Cohen), of controversies about inheritance and property (Nozick; Murphy & Nagel), and of the long-standing philosophical worry about balancing special obligations to intimates with impartial concern for all (Sidgwick, Williams, Singer, Scheffler). Seen from this perspective, Dirac's contribution is a clear, compact formulation of a problem that many philosophers have grappled with in more extended form.

II. DIRAC'S FORMULATION OF THE DILEMMA

Dirac begins from two principles that he takes to be widely accepted in modern societies:

1. **Parental care and sacrifice.** It is good, natural, and socially endorsed that parents care for their children, provide for them, and, where possible, improve their conditions of life, even at cost to themselves. This principle, he notes, has clear analogues in the animal kingdom: many species invest heavily in their offspring. Human parents, similarly, often make substantial sacrifices to give their children better lives.

2. **Equal opportunity for children.** At the same time, Dirac argues, human beings possess a sense of justice that goes beyond animal behaviour. It seems self-evident, he says, that all children born into the world ought to have an equal chance or equal opportunities for development, regardless of the circumstances of their birth.

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These two principles, however, are in immediate tension. If some parents manage, by effort and sacrifice, to provide their children with better education, health, connections, or financial resources, then those children will not have the same opportunities as children whose parents either do not, or cannot, do the same. The first principle thus tends to produce inequalities in opportunities between children.

Conversely, if the second principle were realized strictly—if the state really ensured that all children had equal chances independent of parental behaviour—then additional parental sacrifice would not, in fact, improve a child's prospects relative to others. Parents could still care for their children, but the space within which they could *alter* their relative chances would be heavily constrained. Pursued to the limit, the second principle would thus erode the domain within which the first operates effectively.

Dirac suggests that this structural conflict underlies the familiar opposition between "right–" and "left–wing" ideologies. In the right–wing picture, parents are regarded as primarily responsible for their children and are encouraged and praised when they make sacrifices for them, even though this leads to unequal outcomes. In the left–wing picture, the state undertakes to secure equal opportunity for all children and seeks to make that the only legitimate basis for development, thereby limiting the role of parental advantage. In practice, he notes, actual countries adopt various compromises, seeking to avoid the extremes of each position and the exacerbation of the conflict they entail.

What Dirac does not do is offer a definitive resolution. Rather, he presents the clash of principles as a basic, perhaps permanent, problem of human social life.

III. COMPOUNDING INHERITANCE AND DYNAMIC ADVANTAGE

Dirac's dilemma becomes sharper once we recognize that advantage is not transmitted just once at birth but compounds over time and across generations. This compounding is both financial and non-financial.

A. Financial compounding

Consider a simple model of intergenerational wealth transmission. Let W_t denote the wealth of a family in generation t, and suppose

$$W_{t+1} = (1 + r)\, W_t + Y_t, \tag{1}$$

where $r > 0$ is an average rate of return on wealth, and Y_t represents labour income in generation t.

Even if labour income Y_t were equal across families—an assumption far more egalitarian than reality—differences in initial wealth W_0 would tend to grow over time via compounding. Families that begin with larger W_0 see their advantage expand roughly as $(1 + r)^t$, other things equal. If, more realistically, higher wealth also tends to generate better health, education, and access to lucrative opportunities, thereby raising Y_t, the process is self-reinforcing.

This dynamic has been documented extensively in empirical work. Thomas Piketty, for example, argues that when the long-run rate of return on capital r exceeds the growth rate g of the overall economy, wealth accumulated in the past grows faster than output and income, leading to increasing concentration of wealth and greater importance of inheritance [2]. One need not accept all of Piketty's conclusions to see that Dirac's conflict between parental sacrifice and equal opportunity is not a one-off problem. It is amplified over time by compounding processes.

B. Non-financial compounding

Similar compounding occurs in non-financial domains. Parents transmit to their children various forms of *human capital* (skills, education, health), *social capital* (networks, norms, connections), and *cultural capital* (language, expectations, habits, dispositions). These assets not only improve a child's position at a given moment; they shape the entire trajectory of life, including future earning potential and the ability to invest in the next generation.

As a result, practices that instantiate Dirac's first principle—that parents should strive to improve their children's prospects—create patterns of advantage and disadvantage that, once established, tend to persist and intensify. Within such a dynamic, the second principle—equal opportunity for all children—becomes harder, and eventually impossible, to realize strictly. The dilemma thus acquires a historical and structural dimension.

IV. DIRAC'S DILEMMA IN POLITICAL PHILOSOPHY

While Dirac's articulation is compact and relatively late (the talk was delivered in 1982), the underlying conflict between parental partiality and egalitarian justice has been central to political philosophy since at least the late nineteenth century. In this section, I connect Dirac's dilemma to several major strands of this literature.

A. Rawls and fair equality of opportunity

John Rawls's *A Theory of Justice* [3] is often taken as the foundational work of contemporary liberal egalitarianism. Rawls famously defends two principles of justice, the second of which requires both fair equality of opportunity and that social and economic inequalities be arranged so that they are to the greatest benefit of the least advantaged (the "difference principle").

Rawls's notion of *fair equality of opportunity* goes substantially beyond merely formal equality before the law. It is not sufficient, on his account, that offices and positions be *formally* open to all; rather, individuals with similar talents and willingness to use them should have similar prospects of success, regardless of their social background [3, sect. 12, 14]. This is very close to Dirac's second principle.

At the same time, Rawls insists that the family is part of the "basic structure" of society and thus a primary subject of justice. He nonetheless recognizes that the existence of the family, as an institution in which parents naturally seek to benefit their own children, fundamentally constrains the extent to which fair equality of opportunity can be realized. He writes, in effect, that while institutions should be arranged to mitigate the impact of social contingencies on life chances, no feasible scheme of institutions can eliminate all the effects of family background.[4]

In other words, Rawls accepts something like Dirac's dilemma: the family, and with it the first principle of parental care and sacrifice, is both morally and practically indispensable, but its very existence partly frustrates the realization of the egalitarian ideal of fair equality of opportunity. Rawls's response is, essentially, to seek the best attainable approximation: a system of institutions that significantly reduces, but does not and cannot eliminate, the unequal effects of social starting points.

B. Luck egalitarianism and the problem of the family

Building on Rawls, a group of theorists sometimes called "luck egalitarians" sought to refine the ideal of equality by distinguishing between inequalities that reflect individuals' voluntary choices and those that reflect brute luck. Roughly speaking, they argue that justice requires neutralizing or compensating for inequalities due to brute luck, while allowing inequalities that result from responsible choices.

Ronald Dworkin's account of "equality of resources" is paradigmatic here [5]. Richard Arneson and G. A. Cohen develop related views, arguing that inequalities in welfare or advantage are only just when they trace to agents' choices rather than to circumstances beyond their control [6, 7].

However, once one takes Dirac's first principle seriously, the family poses acute problems for luck egalitarianism. Many of the advantages children enjoy reflect neither their choices nor their brute luck, but the (permissible and valuable) partiality of their parents. Parents choose to invest more or less in their children, and the resulting inequalities in opportunity are not readily classifiable as either deserved or undeserved by the children in luck-egalitarian terms.

Critics such as Elizabeth Anderson have argued that this makes luck egalitarianism morally unattractive. In her influential paper "What is the Point of Equality?" she contends that luck egalitarian policies would have to intrude intolerably into private life or condemn people for unchosen features in ways that undermine their self-respect [8]. Samuel Scheffler likewise emphasizes the importance of "associative duties" to family and friends that cannot be reduced to, or fully subordinated to, impartial egalitarian norms [9].

From Dirac's perspective, these debates can be seen as attempts to respond to the very tension he identifies: strong egalitarian commitments collide with the moral importance of family-based partiality. Luck egalitarians try to draw a principled line between acceptable and unacceptable sources of inequality; their critics argue that the line either fails to do justice to family life or leads to objectionable consequences.

C. The ethics of the family: Brighouse, Swift, and Cohen

More recently, Harry Brighouse and Adam Swift have addressed Dirac's dilemma almost directly in their book *Family Values: The Ethics of Parent–Child Relationships* [10]. They start from the observation that family relationships are intrinsically valuable: they contribute to the flourishing of both parents and children in ways that go beyond the distribution of material resources. At the same time, they recognize that allowing parents to confer advantages on their children conflicts with the ideal of equal opportunity.

Their central question is: *How much inequality should we be prepared to accept in order to sustain the goods associated with family life?* They argue that certain forms of parental partiality (e.g. reading to one's children, spending time with them, providing emotional support, modest gifts) are not only permissible but part of what makes family life valuable. However, they are more critical of practices such as elite private schooling or large, untaxed inheritances, which they regard as hard to justify when they significantly undermine fair equality of opportunity. Their proposed solution is therefore a nuanced one: preserve the core goods of family life while limiting those mechanisms through which parental advantage translates into socially corrosive inequality.

G. A. Cohen addresses a related tension in his book *If You're an Egalitarian, How Come You're So Rich?* [11]. He argues that committed egalitarians who endorse strong principles of distributive justice often live bourgeois lives that include extensive familial partiality. This, he suggests, reveals a kind of moral incoherence: strict egalitarianism appears incompatible with many ordinary, and seemingly admirable, family practices. Cohen does not resolve the conflict so much as expose its depth and urge greater reflective honesty about it.

Both Brighouse & Swift and Cohen thus deepen Dirac's intuition: justice and parental partiality are not easily harmonized. The question is not how to fully reconcile them, but how much injustice we are willing to tolerate for the sake of valuable personal relationships, and how far we are prepared to constrain those relationships for the sake of justice.

D. Inheritance, property, and the legitimacy of bequest

Dirac's second principle—equal chances for all children—also connects to older debates about inheritance, property rights, and redistribution.

On one side, libertarian theorists such as Robert Nozick defend a strong right to private property and voluntary transfer, including bequest [12]. In his "entitlement theory", a distribution of holdings is just if everyone is entitled to the holdings they possess under the principles of justice in acquisition and transfer, regardless of how unequal the outcome may be. On this view, there is no independent requirement that distributions be egalitarian or that inequalities be justified by their effects on the worst off. Parents are entitled to dispose of their property, including by leaving it to their children, and the resulting inequalities in opportunity are morally acceptable if they arise from just processes.

On the other side, egalitarians have argued that strong inheritance rights are hard to reconcile with a commitment to equality of opportunity. Liam Murphy and Thomas Nagel, for example, emphasize that property rights themselves are defined and sustained by the legal and tax systems, and that claims about what individuals "deserve" cannot be detached from the background institutions that structure economic life [13]. From their perspective, substantial taxation of large inheritances can be justified as part of a fair overall system, especially when such inheritances contribute to unacceptable inequalities in life chances.

Economists like Piketty add empirical weight to these concerns, arguing that, absent progressive taxation and other checks, modern economies tend to evolve toward forms of "patrimonial capitalism" in which inherited wealth once again dominates individual achievement [2]. This is effectively a large-scale, data-driven illustration of the compounding process that underlies Dirac's worry.

These debates show that Dirac's dilemma is not merely about the *attitudes* of parents and states, but about the design of concrete institutions governing property, taxation, education, and family law. Different positions in the inheritance debate correspond to different implicit resolutions of the conflict between parental freedom to confer advantage and the egalitarian aspiration to equalize children's life chances.

E. Partiality and impartial morality

At a more abstract level, Dirac's tension exemplifies a familiar and wider problem: the conflict between impartial moral principles that treat all persons' interests as equally important, and partial obligations to family, friends, and associates.

Henry Sidgwick, in *The Methods of Ethics*, already notes the "dualism of practical reason" between egoistic and utilitarian reasons, and more generally the tension between special obligations and impartial benevolence [14]. Later thinkers such as Bernard Williams stress that moral theories which demand pervasive impartiality can alienate individuals from their own projects and relationships [15]. Peter Singer, in contrast, famously argues that we are morally required to make substantial sacrifices to help distant strangers, a view that, if taken seriously, leaves much less moral room for privileging our own children [16].

Samuel Scheffler, in *Boundaries and Allegiances*, articulates a middle position: he maintains that special responsibilities to family and associates are genuine and morally weighty, but also that they are subject to constraints of justice and cannot entirely override impartial considerations [9]. This is very much in the spirit of Dirac's own suggestion that societies must strike a pragmatic compromise between conflicting but individually compelling principles.

V. NON–ZERO–SUM CONSIDERATIONS AND THE COST OF RADICAL EQUALIZATION

The intuitive response to the compounding of inherited advantage is to push more firmly for equalization: if uncorrected parental partiality generates severe inequalities in opportunity, perhaps the state should aggressively redistribute resources and constrain the ways in which parents can favour their own children. Dirac himself gestures toward this thought when he associates the second principle with left–wing ideology and the first with right–wing ideology.

However, two facts are crucial here:

1. Modern economic and social life is not a pure zero–sum game.
2. People respond behaviourally to institutions; incentives shape investment, effort, and innovation.

If total wealth and productive capacity were fixed, questions of justice would concern only how to divide a given pie. In that case, correcting inequalities from inheritance would, at least in principle, leave total resources unchanged. In reality, institutions and policies influence not only the *distribution* but also the *size* of the total product. The ways in which property rights, taxation, and family policies are designed affect whether people invest, save, and take productive risks.

Some redistributive measures are compatible with, and may even promote, long-run prosperity: for example, public investment in education and health, or moderate progressive taxation to fund an effective safety net. But beyond a certain point, especially when expropriation or confiscatory taxation threatens the security of holdings, individuals may reduce investment, withdraw effort, or move their activities into informal or illicit channels. Historical episodes of radical levelling—such as aspects of the early Soviet revolution—have sometimes led not to a stable egalitarian order, but to economic collapse, repression, and generalized scarcity.

From a Rawlsian perspective, this non–zero–sum character of social cooperation is reflected in the difference principle: inequalities in income and wealth are just only if they work to the advantage of the least advantaged over time [3]. Eliminating all inheritance and sharply curtailing parental partiality might move society closer to strict equality of opportunity, but if doing so substantially reduces the overall level of wealth and opportunity, the position of the worst off may, in fact, deteriorate.

Dirac's dilemma thus interacts with a second tension: between the *depth* of egalitarian correction one seeks and the *capacity* of the social–economic system to generate opportunity in the first place. Ignoring the non–zero–sum structure risks policies that destroy the conditions for the very justice they aim to secure.

VI. TOWARDS A NORMATIVE POSITION: FLOORS, MOBILITY, AND MANAGED INEQUALITY

Given the persistent conflict between family-based partiality and egalitarian justice, and the non–zero–sum character of modern economies, what kind of institutional response is plausible?

A. From strict equality to robust opportunity

One important step is to shift the focus from strict equality of opportunity to a combination of:

1. a robust *floor* of opportunities and life conditions for every child, and
2. genuine *social mobility*, such that talent and effort can make a substantial difference to life prospects.

A robust floor includes ensuring that every child has access to:

- adequate nutrition, healthcare, and early childhood support;
- safe and stable housing;
- effective basic education and the possibility of further education or training;
- protection from abuse, neglect, and extreme deprivation.

These are not marginal goods; they require significant public resources and institutional capacity. Yet they still fall short of eliminating all differences in parental endowments and investments. Some children will receive more extensive tutoring, richer cultural experiences, and stronger social networks from their parents than others. Under this model, justice does not demand the erasure of all such differences, but insists that no child be relegated to a life of severely stunted opportunity due to circumstances of birth.

This approach aligns with Rawls's emphasis on ensuring both fair equality of opportunity (to the extent feasible) and a social minimum for the least advantaged, while recognizing, as Rawls himself does, that the family will always limit how far equality of opportunity can go [3]. It also resonates with Brighouse and Swift's effort to protect the core goods of family life while curbing the most harmful forms of educational and economic advantage.

B. Limiting runaway dynastic accumulation

Beyond establishing a floor and promoting mobility, societies can legitimately act to prevent extreme and self-reinforcing concentrations of wealth and power. The aim here is not to render initial conditions identical, but to avoid a situation in which birth overwhelmingly determines prospects and a quasi-hereditary class structure emerges.

In institutional terms, this might involve:

- moderate but effective taxation of large inheritances and estates, with thresholds high enough not to penalize modest intergenerational transfers;
- policies that target *rent-seeking* forms of wealth (monopolies, regulatory capture, unearned privileges) more intensively than wealth generated by innovation and productive investment;
- strong institutions that protect open competition, the rule of law, and merit-based access to education and employment;
- regulation of elite educational and professional "gates" whose closure would otherwise allow advantage to harden into caste-like structures.

These measures accept that some inherited advantage is both inevitable and, within limits, acceptable, but seek to prevent the kind of compounding dynastic dominance that Dirac, Piketty, and many egalitarians find troubling.

C. Accepting managed injustice

From Dirac's starting point, as enriched by the philosophical literature reviewed above, the central normative conclusion is uncomfortable but difficult to avoid: some degree of injustice—in the sense of deviation from strict equality of opportunity—is not merely tolerated but instrumentally justified. The reason is not that inequality is intrinsically valuable, but that the attempt to eliminate it entirely would so disrupt the economic and social conditions of cooperation, and so intrude into vital personal relationships, that overall well-being—including that of the worst off—would plausibly be lower.

This position of "managed inequality" is close in spirit to Rawls's difference principle, to Brighouse and Swift's defence of family values within limits, and to Scheffler's account of associative duties constrained by justice. It rejects both the radical levelling that would extinguish much of the space for parental partiality and the laissez-faire acceptance of compounding hereditary advantage that effectively abandons the egalitarian aspiration.

The task of political design, on this view, is not to resolve Dirac's dilemma once and for all, but to structure institutions so that:

- parental care and sacrifice can flourish within a protected domain;
- no child falls below a decent social minimum or is systematically excluded from meaningful opportunities;
- extreme concentrations of wealth and privilege are checked before they ossify into caste-like structures;
- the productive and innovative capacities of the society are sustained and directed in ways that benefit the least advantaged.

VII. CONCLUSION

Dirac's brief reflection on the futility of war contains a penetrating diagnosis of a basic problem of human society: the structural conflict between the natural and morally valued impulse of parents to advance their own children's interests, and the equally compelling ideal that all children should have equal opportunities in life. This conflict is amplified over time by compounding financial and non-financial advantages and is intertwined with the non–zero–sum character of modern social cooperation.

The history of political philosophy confirms that there is no simple reconciliation of these principles. Rawls, Dworkin, Cohen, Brighouse & Swift, Nozick, Murphy & Nagel, Piketty, and many others have, in different ways, grappled with the tension between family-based partiality, equality of opportunity, and the institutional regulation of inheritance and wealth. The upshot is not a tidy solution, but a recognition that some trade-off is unavoidable: we must decide, as a matter of principle and policy, how much inequality we are willing to accept for the sake of parental freedom and how far we are prepared to limit family-based advantage in the name of justice.

The position sketched here favours a deliberately managed compromise: a robust social floor and real mobility, sustained by institutions that foster both opportunity and productivity, combined with controls on runaway dynastic accumulation. Within that framework, a bounded amount of inherited advantage and resulting inequality is accepted, not because it is just by itself, but because efforts to eradicate it entirely would destroy the conditions for a just and flourishing society.

In this sense, Dirac's dilemma is not a problem to be solved and set aside, but a permanent feature of moral and political life, calling for continuous reflection, adjustment, and restraint.

[1] P. A. M. Dirac, The futility of war, in *The World-wide Implications of a Nuclear War. 1st International Seminar On Nuclear War*, The Science and Culture Series – Nuclear Strategy and Peace Technology, Vol. 1, edited by E. Etim and S. Stipcich (World Scientific, Singapore, 1992) pp. 173–175, 1st International Seminar on Nuclear War, Erice, Italy, 14 – 19 August 1982.

[2] T. Piketty, *Capital in the Twenty-First Century* (Harvard University Press, 2014).

[3] J. Rawls, *A Theory of Justice*, revised edition ed. (Harvard University Press, 1999) first published 1971.

[4] For explicit discussion, see [3, sect. 17, 46]. Rawls acknowledges what he calls "the tendency for the family to undermine the fair value of the equal political liberties" and the difficulty of fully realizing fair equality of opportunity in the presence of the family.

[5] R. Dworkin, *Sovereign Virtue: The Theory and Practice of Equality* (Harvard University Press, 2000).

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[7] G. A. Cohen, *Rescuing Justice and Equality* (Harvard University Press, 2008).

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[9] S. Scheffler, *Boundaries and Allegiances: Problems of Justice and Responsibility in Liberal Thought* (Oxford University Press, 2001).

[10] H. Brighouse and A. Swift, *Family Values: The Ethics of Parent–Child Relationships* (Princeton University Press, 2014).

[11] G. A. Cohen, *If You're an Egalitarian, How Come You're So Rich?* (Harvard University Press, 2000).

[12] R. Nozick, *Anarchy, State, and Utopia* (Basic Books, 1974).

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[14] H. Sidgwick, *The Methods of Ethics*, 7th ed. (Macmillan, 1907) first published 1874.

[15] B. Williams, *Moral Luck: Philosophical Papers 1973–1980* (Cambridge University Press, 1981).

[16] P. Singer, Famine, affluence, and morality, Philosophy & Public Affairs **1**, 229 (1972).